The Vedic Period

The arrival and subsequent influence of newcomers led to the beginning of what is regarded as the Vedic Period (1,700 – 150 BCE). This period is marked by a rustic lifestyle and dedication to the Vedas, which is a collection of religious scriptures. During this time, the people were separated into four social classes known as the Varnas or the caste system. Scholars and priests were known as the Brahmana and sat at the top of the caste system. Warriors were known as the Kshatriya and were second in line. The farmers and traders came next and were known as the Vaishya. The laborers were second from the bottom and known as the Shudra. Lastly, there was another caste known as the Dalits or the Untouchables, who were regarded as being at the bottom of the system. Their job was to mainly handle waste and dead meats.

Initially the caste system was simply a reflection of the occupation one held but over time it seems to have transformed into a categorization by birth. People could not change what caste they were born into and could only change over to a new caste through inter-marriage. This system was ultimately derived from the belief that an individual's status was set by an all-powerful deity.

It is generally accepted that the religious beliefs of the Vedic Period date back to earlier periods. However, these beliefs became formally established as the Sanatan Dharma or the Eternal Order at this time. This is known today as the Hindu religion. The name Hinduism originated from the Indus River where people used to come to worship together. The Sanatan Dharma refers to a set place for everything that exists. Humans, animals, plants and all other beings are meant to live in harmony with one another. This is partly why Hindus are generally vegetarians; they view the slaughter of animals as something that disrupts the Sanatan Dharma.

While Hinduism is known as a polytheistic faith, some of the Hindus view it to be a monotheistic religion. This is because there is one deity Brahman or The Self whose different aspects are divided among the Hindu pantheon. The Hindus believe Braham sets the eternal order and sustains the universe.